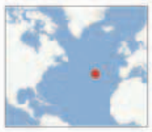
WAR OF THE PORTUGUESE SUCCESSION

AZORES



Date July 26, 1582
Forces French: 56 ships; Spanish: 32 ships
Losses French: 11 ships; Spanish: none

Location Terceira island, Azores

In 1580 the Spanish king, Philip II, took over Portugal. His claim to the throne was contested by Don Antonio, Prior of Crato. Basing himself in the only remaining independent Portuguese territory, the Azores, Don Antonio won the backing of France. Filippo Strozzi, a Florentine who had been commander-in-chief of the French army, recruited a multinational mercenary force that sailed from France for the Azores in June 1582.

Philip II reacted by sending the Marqués de Santa Cruz with a fleet of galleons and armed merchantmen, which reached the Azores on July 22. The Spanish were outnumbered, but their ships were larger. For four days the fleets maneuvered in light winds. On the morning of July 26 they were sailing in opposite directions a few miles apart when Don Lope de Figueroa, commander of the galleon *San Matteo*, made a death-or-glory dash toward the enemy. Five of Strozzi's ships surrounded the isolated galleon, battering it with cannon fire for two hours, but were unable to board the high-sided vessel. Meanwhile, the rest of the Spanish fleet maneuvered to come to Figueroa's aid. The armed merchantmen of their rear squadron arrived first and soon disabled Strozzi's flagship with their powerful guns. A confused mêlée ensued. Santa Cruz, on board *San Martin*, sought out Strozzi's limping ship and bombarded it until most of those on board were dead or wounded. The Spanish boarded the vessel and took Strozzi off, but he was badly injured and soon died. The survivors of his fleet fled in all directions, bringing the battle to a close. Victory in the Azores convinced Santa Cruz that a Spanish Armada could defeat the English.



Spain's takeover of Portugal
The Spanish fleet under Santa Cruz sails into Lisbon to back up Philip II's claim to the Portuguese throne in 1580. Santa Cruz sailed on to defeat the only pocket of resistance to Spanish rule in the Azores in 1582.

1526–1588

MARQUÉS DE SANTA CRUZ

SPANISH ADMIRAL, VICTOR AT LEPANTO AND THE AZORES

Don Álvaro de Bazán was born in Granada, southern Spain. He followed in the footsteps of his father, who was commander of Spain's Mediterranean galleys. Bazán was created Marqués de Santa Cruz in reward for his outstanding performance as a galley commander at Lepanto in 1571. Appointed Admiral of the Ocean in 1583, he showed equal aptitude for warfare under sail at the battle of the Azores. The original idea of sending a fleet to attack England was his, and he would have led the Armada but for his death in February 1588.



ANGLO–SPANISH WARS

CADIZ



Date April 29–May 1, 1587
Forces English: 21 ships; Spanish: 8 galleys
Losses English: 1 ship captured; Spanish: 24

Location Cadiz, southern Spain

In spring 1587 Spain was preparing an Armada to invade England. Sir Francis Drake, on board *Elizabeth Bonaventure*, sailed from Plymouth with a force of warships and armed merchantmen to carry out a preemptive strike against the Spanish. On the afternoon of April 29, Drake's ships appeared off Cadiz and immediately entered the harbor. Brushing aside the galleys defending the port and sinking a Genoese merchant ship that had the audacity to put up a fight, the English settled in among the crowd of ships at anchor, emptying them of their cargoes and setting them on fire. The Spanish galleys harassed the English with hit-and-run attacks and succeeded in capturing one ship that had become isolated. The next day Drake explored further reaches of the harbor, in particular destroying a large galleon belonging to the Marqués de Santa Cruz. But the Spanish brought up heavy guns on shore and began to fire on the English ships. *Golden Lion*, commanded by Drake's vice admiral, William Borough, had to manoeuvre briskly to avoid serious damage. An unfavorable wind confined Drake's ships in the harbor for another night, but they skillfully fended off attacks by Spanish fireships, as well as the persistent attentions of the galleys. Drake sailed out of Cadiz the following day, claiming to have "singed the king of Spain's beard." In practical terms, perhaps the expedition's greatest achievement was the destruction of thousands of barrel staves, making it hard for the Spanish to make sufficient barrels for the food and water required for the Armada.

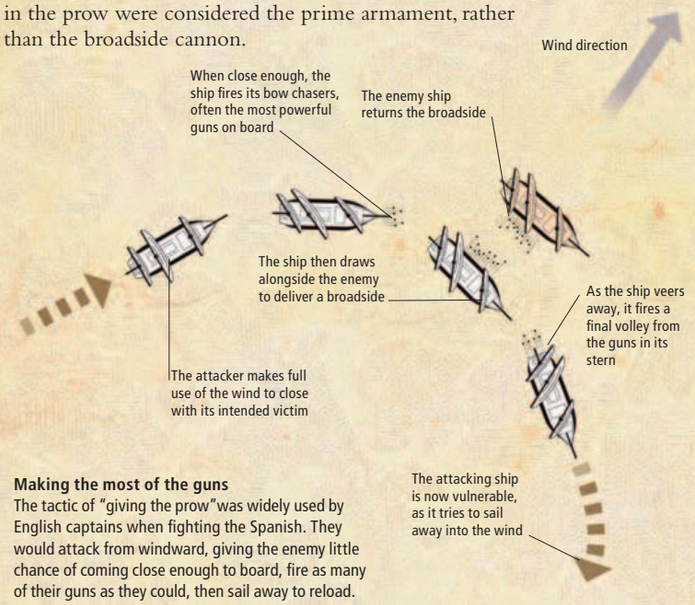
> THE LOSS WAS NOT VERY GREAT, BUT THE DARING OF THE ATTEMPT WAS VERY GREAT INDEED.
>
> **KING PHILIP II OF SPAIN**, COMMENTING ON DRAKE'S RAID ON CADIZ

MAN-OF-WAR TACTICS

GIVING THE PROW

MAKING MAXIMUM USE OF THE WIND

Guns on 16th-century ships were very slow to reload. A ship would typically sail toward an enemy, firing the powerful guns mounted in the prow, and then turn to allow the broadside and stern guns to be fired. If the maneuver was possible, the captain might turn his ship about to fire the other broadside. The ship would withdraw to a safe distance to reload. The guns in the prow were considered the prime armament, rather than the broadside cannon.



Making the most of the guns
The tactic of "giving the prow" was widely used by English captains when fighting the Spanish. They would attack from windward, giving the enemy little chance of coming close enough to board, fire as many of their guns as they could, then sail away to reload.